2.4 The Parties in Conflict

Politicians making negative remarks about each other. Citizens deeply divided over the candidates. A modern-day election? Nope. This happened in 1796, when political parties first competed in an election.

MAIN IDEA Political clashes tested U.S. relationships abroad and the constitutionality of laws passed at home.

ADAMS VS. JEFFERSON

The Federalists and Democratic-Republicans waged a bitter campaign in 1796. John Adams ran on the Federalist side, and Thomas Jefferson represented the Democratic-Republicans. After attacks on both sides, Adams won with 71 electoral votes. He was the first president to govern from Washington, D.C. Jefferson came in second with 68 electoral votes and became vice president. It was not a happy arrangement.

Problems abroad claimed their attention. France began seizing American ships in an effort to prevent U.S. trade with Britain. In response, Adams sent three **envoys**, or ambassadors, to France to settle the problem. The envoys met with French agents known to the American public simply as X, Y, and Z. When the French agents made unreasonable demands and even insisted on being paid a bribe to begin negotiations, the shocked envoys turned them down and returned home.

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The **XYZ Affair**, as the negotiations came to be called, further soured American relations with France. It also hurt the reputation of the Democratic-Republicans, who had supported the French Revolution. When Adams made reports of the affair public, most Americans felt their honor had been attacked, and war fever swept the country. Congress expanded the army, established the navy, and authorized naval vessels to attack French ships that threatened American merchant ships. Congress stopped all trade with France and ended the U.S. alliance with the country.

THE ALIEN AND SEDITION ACTS

Americans cheered Adams's response to the French threat. Riding on a wave of popularity, the Federalists passed the **Alien and Sedition Acts**. The Alien Act allowed the president to expel, for any reason, new immigrants, or aliens, living in the United States—most of whom were Democratic-Republicans. The Sedition Act targeted U.S. citizens, including journalists, who criticized the government. **Sedition** is the act of provoking rebellion.

Democratic-Republicans were quick to respond. For example, in the Kentucky Resolutions, Jefferson condemned the excess of the Alien and Sedition Acts, claiming they violated citizens' freedom of speech and freedom of the press. Adams's opponents fought the acts using a theory called **states' rights**, which declares that individual states have rights the federal government cannot violate. By 1802, the acts had expired, but they had undermined Adams's popularity. In the presidential election of 1800, Jefferson defeated him. The election marked the first peaceful transfer of power from one party to another.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did Jefferson become Adams's vice president in 1796?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** Why did the XYZ Affair increase Adams's popularity?
3. **SYNTHESIZE** How did the Sedition Acts contradict the rights guaranteed under the First Amendment?

A GLOBAL PERSPECTIVE When Congress passed the Sedition Act in 1798, the legislation threatened citizens' freedom of speech and press. Fortunately, Americans can protest against laws they deem unfair and work to overturn them. This is not the case today in North Korea, where any criticism of the government and its leaders results in imprisonment—or worse. The government uses a strong military to enforce its rigid laws. In the 2007 photo shown here, North Korean soldiers take part in a celebration of the 75th anniversary of the founding of the Korean People's Army. What impression do you think the soldiers conveyed to the people of North Korea and the world?

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